to expand the initial conflict beyond Jammu and Kashmir in 1965 was one example. This was not a scenario that Pakistan had prepared for adequately. Standing one's ground against a Pakistani force with superior arms was another. In both 1965 and 1971, the military was given more space and greater say, leading to better outcomes on both occasions. This was also the case with responding in Nathu La in 1967. In 1971, there was additionally much better strategizing in preparation for the use of force, including what at that time was a radical measure of concluding a treaty with the USSR. If there are lessons from the two contrasting periods for the present day, it is both of greater horizontal integration in the Indian national security system and of thinking through a response to an unavoidable challenge.

The following phase, starting with a decisive outcome on the battlefield, began in 1971. The division of Pakistan itself had profound consequences that are not lost on the rest of the region. In an unintended way, the half-hearted attempts by the US and China to assist Pakistan during the conflict only added to India's prestige. Yet, it is in the nature of a power to steadily broaden horizons and that is precisely what India did in its aftermath. Within a short space, there was an attempt to improve ties with the US, leading to a visit by Henry Kissinger in 1973. Kissinger himself was more than aware that this was an attempt to restore the balance after the events of 1971. The American response to India's 1974 nuclear test was, therefore, surprisingly sober. More difficult for India was the decision in 1976 to normalize ties with China and send back an Ambassador after a gap of fifteen years. Both could be seen as expanding its options. The broadening of its vision was also visible in the effort to create a third option in Europe. The acquisition of Jaguars, Mirages and HDW submarine were evidence of this hedging. Prime ministerial visits to the US in 1982 and 1985 as well as the tentative resumption of defence cooperation – involving the Light Combat Aircraft – were further indications. With China, boundary talks resumed in 1981 and reached a point of leadership-level discussions in 1988.

The real impact of India's enhanced stature was felt most in the immediate neighbourhood. The most important challenge was Pakistan, and in 1972 at Shimla, India chose to be generous. It was not that there was an absence of international pressure, including from the USSR itself. There was also a